

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Reuters

Vladimir Putin arrived in Beijing [to meet](#) with **Xi Jinping**. A Kremlin spokesperson said the leaders of Russia and China will “exchange views” on [Donald Trump’s visit](#) to the Chinese capital last week. They are also expected to sign bilateral agreements on energy. Chinese state media suggest the series of visits reflects China’s growing status as a leader of global diplomacy.

Mr Trump claimed **Iran** is “begging” to make a deal to end the war with **America**, but threatened “another big hit” in days without one. On Monday America’s president said he paused a planned attack at the request of Gulf allies because of [negotiations](#). Kazem Gharibabadi, Iran’s deputy foreign minister, said his country was “prepared to confront any military aggression”.

Ken Paxton, Texas’s attorney-general and a **MAGA** ally, was endorsed by Mr Trump in the state’s upcoming Republican Senate primary. The president said [John Conryn](#), the incumbent, “was not supportive of me when times were tough”. [Bill Cassidy](#), a Republican who fell out of Mr Trump’s favour, recently lost Louisiana’s primary; [Thomas Massie](#), another Trump rebel, is running in Kentucky’s Republican primary on Tuesday.

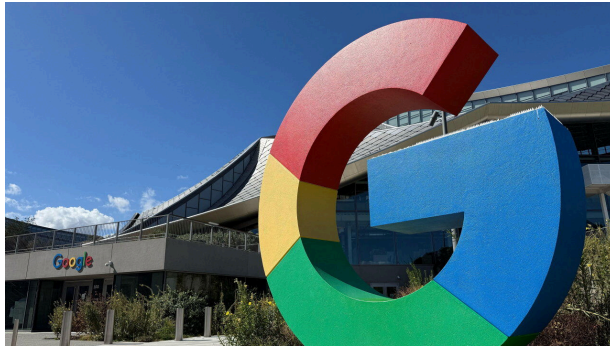
Job vacancies in **Britain** fell to a five-year low in April, reported the country's statistics agency. Analysts suggested that the labour-market slump was caused by the war in Iran, which has raised prices of energy and food. [Unemployment](#) rose to 5% in the three months to March, from 4.9% in the three months to February. Private-sector wages grew by 3%, but were outpaced by inflation.

The World Health Organisation's boss said he was "deeply concerned about the scale and speed" at which the **Ebola** outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo has spread. At least 131 people have died from [the virus](#) and more than 500 have been infected in the regions along the country's border with Uganda. The WHO has declared the flare-up a "public-health emergency of international concern".

Reform UK, Britain's populist-right party, named Robert Kenyon as its candidate in the Makerfield by-election next month. He faces a competitive race against Labour's **Andy Burnham**, Greater Manchester's mayor and [the front-runner to replace Sir Keir Starmer](#). To challenge the prime minister Mr Burnham must become an MP by winning the seat. Mr Kenyon came second in Makerfield during the general election in 2024.

[Humanoid robots](#) could replace almost two-thirds of **China's** shrinking labour force over the next decade, according to a report by Barclays. The British bank estimates that by 2035 China will have [deployed 24m robots](#), equivalent to 4% of its labour force. They could do much of the work in the giant manufacturing sector. The country's population is expected to decline by 37m by then.

Figure of the day: 15%, how much sales rose in the first quarter for GlobalX, an American airline, largely thanks to deportation flights. [Read about](#) the companies profiting from America's immigration crackdown.



Photograph: Alamy

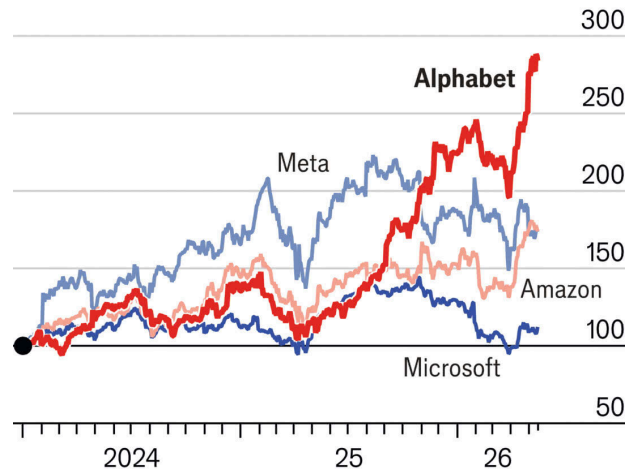
Google provides answers about its AI trajectory

Google will hold its annual developer jamboree on Tuesday. The company will aim to steal the limelight on artificial intelligence back from [Anthropic and OpenAI](#), whose latest models have shown strong capabilities in coding and cybersecurity. Google is expected to unveil improvements to its Gemini models that enable individuals and business customers to build autonomous AI “agents”. These will do more than answer search queries, perhaps including carrying out programming and other tasks on behalf of customers.

Google has other unique strengths in the AI race, too. It makes [its own chips](#), runs its own data centres and builds highly competitive models. It also has a lucrative AI-enhanced digital-advertising business. That gives it surplus cash to invest in AI research, and take advantage of the current intense demand for AI infrastructure. Excitement about Google’s prospects has already seen the share price of Alphabet, its parent company, soar this year.

Artificial advantage

Share prices, January 1st 2024=100



Source: LSEG Workspace



Photograph: Getty Images

Vladimir Putin visits Xi Jinping

Just days after [Donald Trump visited Beijing](#), Russia's leader is making his own trip to the Chinese capital on Tuesday. [Vladimir Putin](#) is set to meet his Chinese counterpart, Xi Jinping, to sign a series of bilateral agreements. The meeting will underline how much Russia relies on China's diplomatic cover and commercial support for its war in Ukraine.

Top of Mr Putin's agenda is finalising a long-awaited deal to build a gas pipeline connecting Siberia to Chinese markets. Russia wants to replace lost European customers. China, meanwhile, may be looking for ways to secure its energy supplies amid disruptions in the Gulf. The visit, so soon after Mr Trump's, will also bolster Mr Xi's foreign-policy credentials at home. State media have already hailed it as evidence of China's emergence "as the focal point of global diplomacy".



Photograph: Getty Images

Africa's Ebola emergency

This week the World Health Organisation declared the spread of the Ebola virus in central Africa to be a “public health emergency of international concern”. So far around 500 cases have been identified in Congo—although this is certainly an undercount—and at least 131 people have died. Cases have been reported in neighbouring Uganda, while Burundi, Rwanda and South Sudan are on high alert.

African countries have vastly improved their response to Ebola outbreaks since 2014, when more than 11,000 people died during an epidemic that lasted two years. But there are still reasons for concern. There is no vaccine for this strain of the virus, and public-health efforts will be further complicated by the weakness of the Congolese state in the conflict-ridden east. [Cuts by America](#) and other donors to international health programmes also mean there is less money to respond. Expect the caseload and death toll to rise further in the coming weeks.



Photograph: Reuters

Chanel is chic again

France's storied luxury *maison* reported its financial results for 2025 on Tuesday. Sales and operating profit rose 2% and 5%, respectively. Under its new designer, Matthieu Blazy, Chanel has once more become [one of fashion's hottest companies](#). Shoppers across the globe have clamoured for his latest collections of fringed skirts, puffy bags and two-toned shoes: several models have sold out everywhere. Foot traffic at Chanel boutiques in China was 130% higher during this Lunar New Year shopping weekend in February than the year before.

But Chanel is an outlier in the luxury industry. After a post-pandemic spree, consumers have mostly plumped for [posh resorts and wellness packages](#) over fancy garments. Conflict in the Gulf (a large luxury market) has depressed consumer sentiment worldwide. Even rivals like [Hermès](#), once thought immune from the downturn, have suffered. Chanel will worry that its current popularity is just another fad for luxury-lovers. In the words of the late Karl Lagerfeld, the brand's creative director for three decades: "fashion is ephemeral, dangerous and unfair."



Photograph: Teresa Castracane Photography

Moreland becomes the Moor

Wendell Pierce, best known for playing the dedicated, even-keeled Bunk Moreland in “The Wire” (and the struggling musician Antoine Baptiste in “Treme”), will play Othello in the [Shakespeare Theatre Company](#)’s production of one of the bard’s great tragedies. Their “Othello” opens on Tuesday in Washington, DC and will run for more than five weeks. The cast and crew will be hoping to recreate the success last year of the play’s first staging on Broadway since 1982. With Denzel Washington, an even bigger star than Mr Pierce, it set a record for gross sales (some tickets sold for \$1000).

Like Mr Washington, Mr Pierce started off as a stage actor, and brings a commanding presence to a famously challenging role. He must make the audience believe that Othello, a noble Moor who is a general in Venice’s army, can come to heed the slander of his rival Iago and murder his own blameless wife. Performed well, “Othello” becomes a haunting study of jealousy, hubris and manipulation.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Who along with his then wife Melinda, founded one of the world's largest charitable foundations in 2000?

Monday: Which martial artist from Hong Kong had a Hollywood hit with the film "Rush Hour"?

Education is the passport to the future, for tomorrow belongs to those who prepare for it today.

Malcolm X